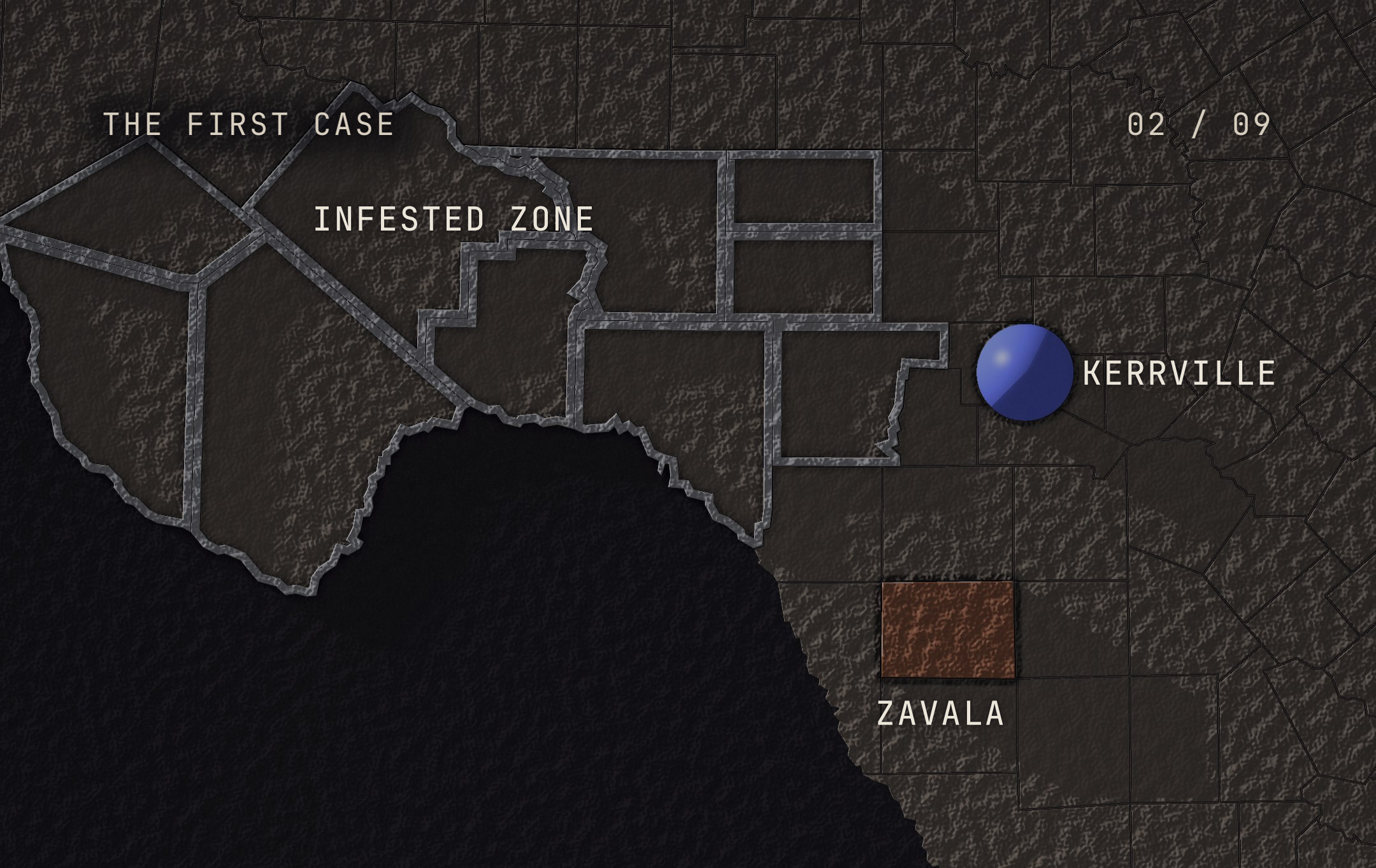
AI picks where Texas fights this fly

New World screwworm lays its eggs in open wounds. USDA uses AI models to choose where, when and how many sterile flies to release against it.
Drawn to illustrate.





It reached a calf in Zavala County

Screwworm was confirmed in a Zavala County calf on June 3rd, and the calf has recovered. The infested zone lies in parts of the rimmed counties. Movement restrictions reach into parts of 12 counties, the Texas Animal Health Commission says. Drawn to illustrate.

43 premises. 17 counties.

The Texas Animal Health Commission counts 43 Texas premises with at least one confirmed detection, across 17 counties. One windmill is one premises.
Drawn to illustrate.



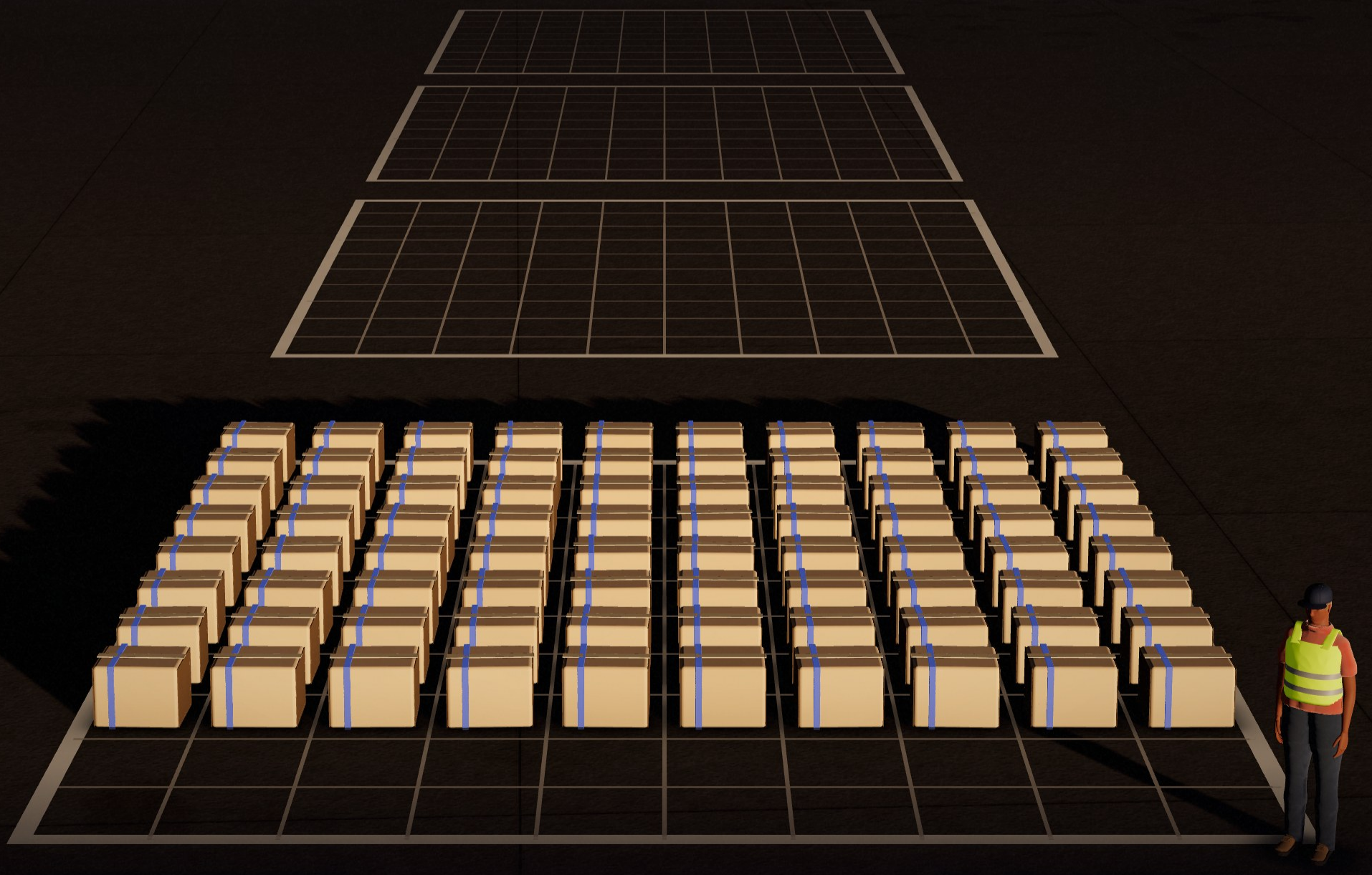
The models pick the place

USDA’s research service has models that use AI to predict where the fly is likely to take hold. They already pick areas for surveillance, fly trapping and sterile fly releases, says Kim Lohmeyer, who directs the Kerrville laboratory. Drawn to illustrate.



More than 80 million a week

USDA says its Edinburg facility deploys more than 80 million sterile flies a week over Texas and Mexico and can disperse up to 100 million. A production plant being built in South Texas is projected at 300 million. One box is a million flies. Drawn to illustrate.



It worked before



USDA says sterile flies helped eradicate screwworm from the United States in 1966 and helped wipe out a small Florida Keys outbreak in 2017. USDA now uses AI models to choose where those flies go. Drawn to illustrate.

Over 36,000 seen. No case found.

USDA’s drones flew over Texas more than 2,000 times since June, KRGV reported. They found no case among the more than 36,000 animals observed. Officials called the drones not foolproof. Each animal drawn stands for a thousand seen. Drawn to illustrate.



The trailer the models can't predict

The models can’t predict every scenario, Kim Lohmeyer says. Lohmeyer names one especially, people moving infested animals. Drawn to illustrate.



Keep it home. Call it in.

Never move an animal that shows signs, USDA says. The Texas Animal Health Commission asks for a report within 24 hours of suspicion, to a region office or its veterinarian on call at 1-800-550-8242.
Drawn to illustrate.

